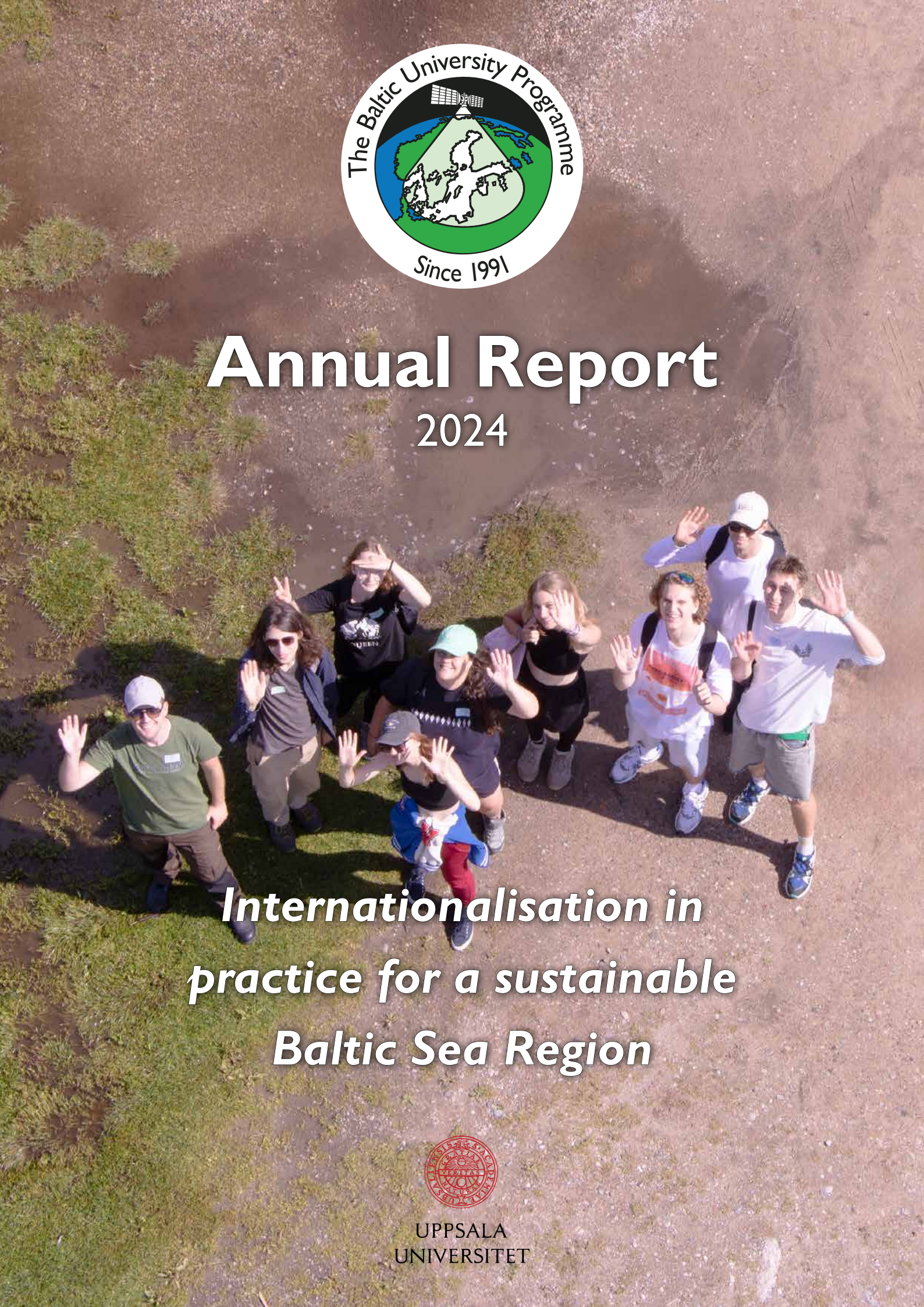


Annual Report

2024

Internationalisation in practice for a sustainable Baltic Sea Region

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The photo on the cover is
taken in the Nemunas Delta, Lithuania.
Photo by Pontus Ambros.

Table of contents

Director's welcome 4
This is The Baltic University Programme (BUP) 6
BUP Presidency 7

Projects

RESCUU 10
CAPABLE 12

Education

BUP Course Platform 16
BUP educational material bank 17
BUP Supervisor Collegium Training 18
Introduction to ESD – Education for Sustainable Development 20
BUP Teachers' Day 21
BUP Teachers Course 2023-2024 22

Researchers

BUP PhD Award 26
Mobility Grant 27
BUPRaP Roadshow 28
Research within the BUP 29

Students

BUP Student Conference 32
BUP Science and Sail 34
BUP Master Thesis Training 36

BUP organisation

Participating universities 40
BUP IROs Network 41
Organisational structure 42
The Secretariats 43
The National Centres 46
BUP communication 47

Increased interest in the Programme

The Baltic University Programme (BUP) has continued to grow in 2024 and we have seen an increasing interest from universities to be a part of the BUP. This past year alone we have been joined by 18 new universities, the BUP is now a Programme with 116 participating universities! We are also happy to have welcomed new colleagues to the BUP International Board and new universities as hosts for some of the BUP National Centres.

We are grateful to see that the calls and events that we offer to our colleagues and students are relevant and of interest and that we are improving our reach within the Programme. This is evident when you look at the number of applicants to our events and the number of people involved in our projects, which have increased in 2024. Noteworthy is that we had over 400 applicants to our Student Conference and more than 300 applicants to attend the summer course Science and Sail. This success is thanks to a common effort in the Programme by the Associated Secretariats, National Centres, all the contact persons at BUP participating universities and the Coordinating Secretariat.

We also see an increasing interest from international officers and colleagues working with internationalisation issues. In October during the Czech Republic Presidency, a three-day meeting was organised for International Relations Officers (IROs). Close to 50 colleagues took part and thanks to our engaged colleagues we have seen the creation of the BUP International Relations Officers (IROs) Network as a result of this event. We look forward to seeing this network continue to grow and the synergies that their meetings and work can bring to the BUP.

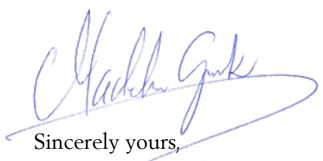
As an outcome of the BUP Course Platform that we launched in 2022, we were this year able to launch the BUP educational material bank, as a service for teachers at our participating universities. As a continuation of our efforts with the BUP Course Platform, the material bank gives colleagues at BUP participating universities access to all the course material. This will open for the use of individual lectures, tasks, readings and other course material in local courses. Colleagues can choose to use parts of the material in their courses or when creating new courses at their university.

This year we finished the Swedish Institute-financed project 'Resilience of Education: Sustainability and Cooperation for Ukrainian Universities' (RESCUU). The project has provided several events, online and physical, targeting Ukrainian teachers, students, and researchers. The events focused on the knowledge and experiences needed to overcome the consequences of the war, as well as problems of sustainability in connection to the war. With one project ending, we were at the same time granted a new Swedish Institute-financed project with the aim to assist Ukrainian universities in the education of the next generation of researchers, their PhD students. For this, the Common Academic Practices and Abilities in Learning for Research (CAPABLE) project started in 2024.

For the new initiative the Supervisor Collegium Training we learned from the 220 applications that there is a great interest among researchers and teachers in learning in their role of being a supervisor. The training aimed toward enhancing and developing the participant's supervisionary pedagogies, as well as sharing experiences among colleagues from different disciplines and academic cultures. Many universities do not offer any trainings or courses for supervisors, which makes this training important for BUP to arrange as a service for supervisors.

We are looking forward to this upcoming year when we will finally welcome researchers to meet in person for the BUP Symposium, shining a light on research being conducted in the Baltic Sea Region. In November Uppsala University invites you, colleagues at participating universities to contribute to the BUP Symposium 2025 on the theme 'Strengthening the Security and Resilience of the Baltic Sea Region – Environmental, Political, Social, and Economic Shocks and Crises'. Sustainability and resilience have become more commonly discussed lately among scholars. How crises, war and disasters hinder the progress towards the UN Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs), and how resilience as a concept is used in studying and analysing the behaviour in societies when suffering from crises and their measures toward stability. In times of increasing instability in societies, the role that universities have in contributing to the achievement of the 17 SDGs and the role of regional cooperation in enhancing security, resilience and preparedness in the Baltic Sea Region, becomes increasingly important for what the future will be. Russia´s invasion of Ukraine stressed the importance of building a common and comprehensive approach to regional security. Cooperation and knowledge are crucial to overcome the most pressing challenges. Universities as knowledge producers and their broader transformations becoming more societally engaged are crucial in finding solutions to current crises. With our 116 participating universities we have a role to play in contributing to this work. Connected to the Symposium we will also host a meeting with the Supervisor Collegium and arrange the PhD Students Training.

With joined forces in knowledge production from and between different disciplines, learning from each other in a multi-, inter-, and transdisciplinary setting, together with a willingness for collaboration, we lay a foundation for the future of our common region. To see that The Baltic University Programme continues to grow, along with the interest in all that we do and offer, gives us a push to continue developing the BUP together with colleagues and students at our participating universities.



Sincerely yours,
Madeleine Granvik,
Director, Associate Professor



This is The Baltic University Programme (BUP)

The Baltic University Programme (BUP) is one of the largest university cooperations in the world, with 116 participating universities in ten countries of the drainage area of the Baltic Sea.

The Programme strives to find novel ways of interaction among universities and between universities and society. The main aim is to enhance strong regional educational and research communities but also to foster a greater awareness of sustainable development, environmental protection, and democracy in the Baltic Sea Region. The BUP supports the key role that universities play in democratic, peaceful and sustainable development.

Our aim is achieved by being an open and inclusive organisation, developing and offering university courses, trainings, conferences, symposiums and projects supporting multi and interadisciplinary academic cooperations, and by participating in transdisciplinary cooperations with other stakeholders in society. We focus on our 10 BUP research themes, which relate to the UN Sustainable Development Goals, intended as a source of information where BUP colleagues can network and exchange knowledge as well as collect and submit material.

Each participating university pays an annual fee which entitles them to send its administrative staff, researchers, teachers, and students to BUP activities, courses, and conferences. Our participating universities are located in Czechia, Estonia, Finland, Germany, Latvia, Lithuania, Poland, Slovakia, Sweden and Ukraine.

The Programme is managed by a Coordinating Secretariat at Uppsala University, Sweden. Moreover, three Associated Secretariats, at Hamburg University of Applied Sciences, Lodz University of Technology and Åbo Akademi University, have their specialised tasks focusing on teachers, students, and PhD students. An integral part of our organisation is the BUP National Centres which deal with the network coordination in each country. The long term development and the strategy of the BUP is attended to by the BUP International Board.

The BUP has been around since 1991. Throughout the years, thousands of students, teachers, researchers and administrative staff has taken part in courses, conferences, projects, exchanges, excursions, sails, seminars, workshops and much more. During 2024 the BUP hosted a range of academic activities and educational opportunities. Some of the main focuses during the past year have been the CAPABLE-project, the creation of the BUP IROs Network, the first ever BUP Supervisor Collegium Training, the development and introduction of new National Centres as well as organising the Master Thesis Training, Student Conference and Science and Sail.

The Baltic University Programme's logotype. The logotype shows the earth and a satellite focusing on the Baltic Sea Region. This is our history, reflecting on how the BUP set up satellite TV arrangements in the early 1990's. An innovative approach to teaching and networking is as much part of our legacy as it is how we wish to continue working with our aims in the future.

BUP Presidency

The Presidency was introduced in 2016 in order to decentralise and share responsibilities with the BUP National Centres and by this establish a formal platform for them to influence the organisation in practice. Each BUP National Centre coordinate the BUP Presidency for six months according to a rotating schedule.

The universities in the country holding the BUP Presidency are responsible for the content and arrangement of some of the BUP's annual events, as well as the promotion of the BUP in their own country, along with additional events and activities aimed at strengthening the Programme in the country and the region as a whole.

The National Centre in Poland, which is located at Lodz University of Technology, coordinated the BUP Presidency in the spring of 2024.

The National Centre participated in the organisation of the BUP Student Conference by working with the elaboration of the agenda, selection of the students, and a speech about BUP history. The Centre also organised the BUP Center Directors meeting in Lodz. During the Presidency, there were two additional events held. The International Scientific Symposium on circular economy was organised by Bialystok University of Technology, on 21-23 April 2024, entitled 'The Role of Universities and Research for Sustainable Regional Development'. A special session was held at the second Scientific Conference from the series "Universities facing challenges of sustainable development". The session aimed to review activities and good practices in relation to how universities are involved in the implementation of the 17 UN Sustainable Development Goals.

On the BUP website, you can read the full Presidency report written by the BUP National Centre in Poland.

The BUP National Center in Czechia, which is located at the University of Ostrava, coordinated the BUP Presidency in the autumn of 2024.

During the Presidency the National Centre at the University of Ostrava organised the 'BUP meeting of International Relations Officers (IROs)' where IROs at BUP participating universities were invited to meet. This meeting has led to the creation of the BUP IROs Network. Another event within the Presidency was the BUPRaP Roadshow led by Professor Walter Leal, Hamburg University of Applied Sciences. The target group was PhD students and the two main topics were "Optimising Efforts in Scientific Publishing on Sustainable Development" and "Fostering Scientific Cooperation via European and Non-European Funded Projects on Sustainable Development".

On the BUP website, you can read the full Presidency report written by the BUP National Centre in Czechia.



The Centre Directors and staff from the BUP Coordinating Secretariat at the Centre Directors meeting held at Lodz University of Technology.

Photo: Krzysztof Ciesielski



Participants at the International Scientific Symposium held in Bialystok.

Photo: Dariusz Piekut, Bialystok University of Technology



Participants at the BUP meeting of International Relations Officers in Ostrava.

Photo: Lara Kerschl

Projects

The Baltic University Programme initiates, coordinates, and participates in inter- and transdisciplinary projects in an inter-cultural academic environment as a way of supporting the creation of strong educational and research communities in the Baltic Sea Region. During 2024, a couple of projects were led by the BUP Coordinating Secretariat at Uppsala University and each project had multiple BUP participating universities as project partners.

Page 10

RESCUU

Page 12

CAPABLE

RESCUU

The project RESCUU (Resilience of Education: Sustainability and Cooperation for Ukrainian Universities) ended in 2024. It was aimed at contributing to the resilience of wartime Ukraine's educational institutions and supporting Ukrainian teachers, students and researchers who remain in Ukraine and work or study at Ukrainian universities.

This project provided several events, both online and physical, aimed at three target groups: teachers, students and researchers. The content of the events was focused on knowledge and experiences needed to overcome the consequences of the war, as well as problems of sustainability in connection to the war.

By participating in international events within the framework of the project, teachers and students received support from their international peers and colleagues, as well as established contacts for collaboration with universities in the Baltic Sea Region. The project aimed to help colleagues and students to be prepared to take an active role in post-war reconstruction. The last year of the project implementation was very successful.

The biggest event was the BUP Student Conference 'Changed circumstances and new threats for sustainability in the Baltic Sea Region' held between 15-18 April 2024 at Poznan University of Technology, Poland. As a part of the RESCUU project, 30 students from Ukraine came to Poland to meet students and teachers from partner universities and across the region, to exchange experiences and talk about their situation and life in Ukraine. An exhibition focusing on the war in Ukraine was brought from Kyiv by the group from the National Technical University of Ukraine 'Igor Sikorsky Kyiv Polytechnic Institute'.

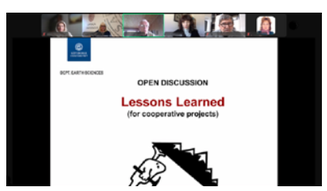
The event approached the conflict in the region from a sustainability standpoint, increasing knowledge amongst students and allowing them to network with fellow peers. The participants discussed some of the effects of the war in Ukraine within various fields and sectors. Furthermore, they looked at the effects of the war in Ukraine within a wider European context for students to understand the relevance and implications within sustainability science and their own country.

Another group of students from Ukrainian universities met for the Boot Camp 'Science and Innovation for the Reconstruction of Ukraine' in July in Kyiv. Together with experts they looked at the basics of civil security, military ecology, and humanitarian demining. They investigated the role of modern technologies (artificial intelligence and 3D printing) in the post-war reconstruction of Ukraine and discussed necessary changes in the most basic areas of the country's life during and after the war. Also, the participants were able to propose their scenarios for the reconstruction of Ukraine.



The project included three work packages; Training for university teachers, International cooperation boot camps for university students, and Strengthening research cooperation.

Photo: Vectonauta via Freepik



Participants at the online workshop 'Research Cooperation Against Consequences of the War'.

Photo: Lyudmyla Babak



Liudmyla Vlasiuk, second from the left, pictured with colleagues during her study visit at Uppsala University.

Photo: Liudmyla Vlasiuk

The researchers were not less active. Thus, during spring 2024 eight researchers from Ukrainian universities were given the possibility to make study visits and establish contacts with colleagues who work in the same fields at Lund University, University of Gothenburg and Uppsala University. The visits and previous work in the project were summed up at the final workshop on 'Research Cooperation Against Consequences of the War' which was held online in October.

The BUP Coordinating Secretariat, project partners and all those colleagues involved in the project hope to carry on with the cooperation created as a part of the project.

This project gave possibilities to the BUP and involved partners to work at supporting Ukrainian colleagues in this difficult time. It also helped to bring an understanding of the complexity of the region: the situation in Ukraine is closely related to the challenges for the sustainability of the whole region.

The RESCUU project became possible thanks to the support of the Swedish Institute which provided the financing for the project.



In connection to the BUP Student Conference there was an exhibition focusing on Ukraine.

Photo: Anna Stawiarz, Poznan University of Technology

Funded by Swedish Institute

As part of the cooperation in the Baltic Sea region, SI funds exchanges and joint projects for individuals, organisations and companies.



The Ukrainian students all traveled together to the conference.

Photo: Khrystyna Martyniak



Ukrainian students at the 'Cultural Party' held during the BUP Student Conference. Here they shared food, drinks, and stories from their home country.

Photo: Pontus Ambros

CAPABLE

The BUP puts efforts into assisting Ukrainian universities in the education of the next generation of researchers and university teachers, by jointly supporting their PhD students. For this, the project CAPABLE (Common Academic Practices and Abilities in Learning for Research) was developed.

With Ukraine coming closer to the EU, there is a distinct need to align, integrate and prepare the education frameworks and systems with European education standards, in particular the European Research Area. PhD students are the target group that is most closely related to such needs, therefore the CAPABLE project aims to support young academics in Ukraine to develop skills and competences in line with the standard in EU countries. So the project aims to provide knowledge, skills and network opportunities to PhD students from Ukraine. This is done by organising training for them in a mixed group with PhD students from other universities within the BUP; and by contributions from senior experts from BUP participating universities in the EU.

The training consists of three parts:

1. Online seminar series
2. PhD student conference in Uppsala
3. Online course on academic pedagogies

Two parts of the training have already been implemented with the most interactive one being a PhD students conference, which was organised 11-14 November 2024 in Uppsala. This event included presentations on international academic cooperation, interdisciplinary research, research presentations and publications. The students took part in a Design Thinking Workshop and a workshop on networking for academic cooperation in the Baltic Sea Region. One of the workshops was focused on mental health and well-being which is also an important issue for the PhD students. Also, participants had the possibility to give and get input on their work during peer-review sessions as well as they received individual feedback from senior experts in their field.

In total 45 PhD students from 26 BUP universities participated in the event, which was organised in a hybrid mode, giving a chance for the students from Ukraine to take part as well. The participants gave the event an overall 8.7/10 rating. They expressed that the conference had been worthwhile to attend, in terms of their studies, future aspirations, and careers. The PhD students noted that they gained a lot of new contacts. Furthermore, they stated that they received knowledge and feedback as well as new ideas as a result of participating in the conference.

The CAPABLE project is run by the BUP Coordinating Secretariat and will conclude in 2025.

The best part of the event was the vibrant exchange of ideas during both formal sessions and informal discussions. Engaging with peers who share similar challenges and ambitions was incredibly motivating.

Quote from Sofia Markina, one of the participants at the CAPABLE PhD student conference.

The teachers and researchers from the project partners universities - Ivan Franko National University of L'viv (Ukraine), Lodz University of Technology (Poland), V.N. Karazin Kharkiv National University (Ukraine) and WSB University in Poznan (Poland) - have actively contributed to the implementation so far. The Coordinating Secretariat at Uppsala University, Uppsala, Sweden, is a lead partner and involves other BUP universities in the network as well.

The project is financed by the Swedish Institute (SI).



During the Design Thinking Workshop, the participants applied designers' tools to real life problems.

Photo: Lara Kerschl



All the PhD students received feedback and support from senior experts in their field. Pictured is a group of students together with Professor Tomasz Branka (third from the left) from Adam Mickiewicz University who also gave the presentation 'First Impressions Matter: Presentation Intros Unleashed'.

Photo: Pontus Ambros



Participants and experts at the BUP CAPABLE PhD student conference in Uppsala.

Photo: Pontus Ambros



The participants worked a lot in groups during the conference where they got the opportunity to meet and learn together with PhD students from all over the Baltic Sea Region.

Photo: Lara Kerschl

Funded by Swedish Institute

Education

One of the key missions of The Baltic University Programme is the creation of educational courses and trainings from different academic disciplines with both theoretical and practical focuses. These trainings and courses are created by colleagues at BUP participating universities, some of which are available as massive open online courses (MOOCs) on the BUP Course Platform, some as courses where the participants achieve ECTS credits and some are created for BUP teachers.

Page 16

BUP Course Platform

Page 17

BUP educational material bank

Page 18

BUP Supervisor Collegium Training

Page 20

Introduction to ESD – Education for Sustainable Development

Page 21

BUP Teachers Day

Page 22

BUP Teachers Course 2023-2024

BUP Course Platform

The BUP courses are created as massive open online courses (MOOCs) that are unique in that they focus on sustainability in a Baltic Sea Region context. On the BUP Course Platform, there are currently ten interdisciplinary courses created by colleagues at participating universities available.

One of the key missions of the Programme is the creation of courses from different academic disciplines with both theoretical and practical focuses. In the past few years, the BUP has been working to create a wide range of digital educational material and courses from an intercultural, interdisciplinary, and regional perspective. This led to the creation of the BUP Course Platform in 2023. Our courses are linked to the 10 themes of the BUP, which have a base in sustainability science.

The courses are developed by close to 100 colleagues from BUP participating universities, a true regional teamwork. The courses are offered as massive open online courses (MOOCs). This means that they can be accessed by anyone independent of time and place, as self-paced distance courses and, of course, free of charge.

By the end of 2024, the following courses were available:

- Conditions and Challenges of Sustainability
- Economic Sustainability- an introduction
- Sustainable Food Systems in the Baltic Sea Region
- Sustainable Tourism in the Baltic Sea Region
- The Baltic Sea Environment; Challenges and Solutions
- Rethinking the Baltic Sea Region
- Introduction to Virtual Exchange
- Climate Change in the Baltic Sea Region
- Energy Transition in the Baltic Sea Region
- Introduction to Education for Sustainable Development (ESD)

In developing courses, colleagues from BUP participating universities representing different disciplines and academic cultures, contribute with their knowledge and experiences. The work endeavours to be based on the BUP working model, which means working in interdisciplinary and intercultural teams of cooperation. This way of cooperation offers opportunities to learn from each other as well as enhance course material with different perspectives and academic cultures.

The courses are open to all who are interested in them and they are completely free to enroll in with no previous knowledge or pre-requisites necessary. The BUP therefore welcomes all to take these courses; students, teachers, researchers, administrators, and all members of the public. The level of the courses on the BUP Course Platform are designed at the undergraduate level, however, with teaching from renowned experts across the Baltic Sea Region and vivid examples, the courses should be of interest to all.

In the past year, work has been done to increase the accessibility of the course material, work that continues.

The BUP is happy to welcome new contributions to all of our current courses that are published on the Course Platform. There is great value in providing new material. This could be for example a lecture focused on a specific case in the Baltic Sea Region, an analysis lecture focusing on an issue not yet covered, or perhaps a new theoretical angle. If you would like to make a contribution, then please contact the Coordinating Secretariat.

In 2024 a new course was published on the BUP Course Platform. The course *Introduction to Education for Sustainable Development (ESD)* opened for enrolment in the autumn. For this course, contributions have been made by colleagues from Åbo Akademi University, Uppsala University, Wageningen University, University of Helsinki, and Kaunas University of Technology.

The course *Introduction to Education for Sustainable Development (ESD)* consists of four parts:

1. Introduction and background.
2. Transformative learning and learning for change.
3. ESD and sustainability competencies.
4. ESD in practice.



The course *Introduction to Education for Sustainable Development (ESD)* is now available as a MOOC course on the BUP Course Platform.

Photo: Laura Kapfer on Unsplash

BUP educational material bank

As part of the efforts to develop and make educational materials widely available within the Programme, the BUP educational material bank was launched in 2024. The material bank is envisioned to give colleagues at BUP participating universities the opportunity to download and use a wide range of material from the courses on the BUP Course Platform while creating local courses at their university.

The BUP educational material bank is an opportunity for those who are currently teaching courses at participating universities to integrate BUP educational material from the bank into their teaching. The material can be used as a whole or as part of a course, for example, there are many lectures that may prove useful.

The BUP sees further opportunities with the material developed for each MOOC course on the BUP Course Platform. For example, teachers are able to develop more advanced local courses at their university and to give students credits by adding material, assignments, seminars, etc. These initiatives are taken at each BUP participating university. In this case, there could also be the possibility to promote virtual exchange cooperation between BUP participating universities when running credit bearing courses.

BUP Supervisor Collegium Training

This training program was created as a part of the BUP's commitment to education and supporting colleagues in their academic teaching. The training aimed toward enhancing and developing the participant's supervisionary pedagogies.

Having the role of a supervisor could be rather challenging and colleagues are seldom offered any form of training on this topic. This training welcomed supervisors, especially those who had recently completed their doctorate, assistant lecturers, as well as seniors, professors, and docents, however, all those who had a desire to refresh their skills could participate.

This training began with an online seminar series training. The training, with five online seminars, was designed to offer a broad but focused introduction to supervision, supervisionary techniques, and supervision pedagogies. The seminars together formed a training package and when completed by the participant resulted in the award of a diploma. The training ended with an optional in person training workshop where the participants were given the chance to discuss and exchange experiences and knowledge.

The BUP Supervisor Collegium workshop was held between 21-22 May at Uppsala University, hosted by the BUP Coordinating Secretariat. The program for the workshop was designed to offer a broad but focused presentation regarding various elements of supervision, supervision techniques, and educational pedagogies. Some of the sessions were a direct follow-up to those discussed online, whilst some were additional topics. At the center of the program, was collaboration. All BUP events promote and foster networking, cooperation and internationalisation, and this was the case here, with clear emphasis placed on workshops, discussions, and practical exercises as well as how participants and the BUP can collaborate in the future.

The program included five different sessions;

- Scientific communication
- Co-supervision
- Communication and coaching
- Evaluation practices
- Future collaboration and activities.

As a result of the workshop, there was a discussion on further needs, ideas for networking, and concrete activities. Several suggestions were raised to meet annually in the BUP Supervisor Collegium to discuss academic ethics, time management, stress management, leadership, promotion, sharing lessons to be learned, cross-country learning, and having a writing retreat for funding.



Helena Lindqvist and Cesar Pay Gomez, Uppsala University, giving a presentation on scientific communication at the workshop in Uppsala.

Photo: Evan Goss

"As a result of taking part, I have now started discussing my supervision style with my PhD students more openly. This might be a sign that I became more confident and open to adapt to specific needs of the students over the course of the program."

Quote from Stefan Reinsch, one of the participants at the BUP Supervisor Collegium workshop.

The evaluation of the workshop included many positives, especially in reference to the sessions included in the program. The participants gave a rating of 9.4/10 in response to the question of to what extent the workshop had been worthwhile in attending in terms of supervision skills, future aspirations, and career. Furthermore, the participants gave the event an overall 9.7/10 rating. A selection of views can be found below.

"It was very nice and inspiring. I liked the mode of presentation and the recommendations for speaking and listening are of great importance not only for PhD supervision."

"I did not know much about coaching before and the facilitator was excellent."

"I now have lots of things to share with my colleagues at home, so that not only my supervising practice will improve."

When it came to ways of improving for the future, the participants would have liked more discussion time to build on what they learned in the sessions. Moreover, dedicating more time to the session on future opportunities and collaboration would have also been appreciated. Participants would have liked the time to be able to share their own links, organisation and courses. Inviting and hosting international experts would also be welcomed, for greater best-practice sharing and collaboration.



Participants at the BUP Supervisor Collegium workshop in Uppsala.

Photo: Evan Goss



The in-person training included a lot of group work and discussions. Meeting colleagues from all over the Baltic Sea Region laid the foundation for future collaboration.

Photo: Evan Goss

Introduction to ESD – Education for Sustainable Development

In cooperation with the Open University, the BUP National Centre and BUP's Associated Secretariat at Åbo Akademi University hosted this 5 ECTS online course.

The course ran during the autumn semester of 2024 and it had 48 participants from 10 different countries. There were 32 representatives from BUP participating universities who took part for free in the course.

The course was aimed at students and educators who wanted to:

- Understand ESD and how it broadens the holistic and interdisciplinary understanding of sustainability.
- Understand how competencies like critical thinking, future scenarios skills, and collaborative decision-making are promoted by ESD.
- Understand the role of ESD in both formal and informal learning.
- Get an insight into the state of ESD at their own university.

The course contained short, recorded presentations explaining the core of ESD (what it is, examples of ESD competencies, explanations and examples of formal/non-formal learning, good practices). The literature explained the Holistic and interdisciplinary of sustainable development. The participants also got the task to make a survey on the state of ESD at the own institution/department/university.



Photo: Austin Rucker on Unsplash

BUP Teachers' Day

At the BUP Teachers' Day 2024, held on 16 April, there was a focus on how educators can bring the Science of Compassion and Wellbeing into their courses. The event is open to all teachers in higher education within The Baltic University Programme.

The participants were given the possibility to network, get new knowledge and inspiration, and share experiences and best practices with colleagues around the Baltic Sea Region. During the event, they got a first insight into some best practices for engaging students and colleagues and were given an introduction to SEE Learning (Social, Emotional and Ethical Learning). The coach was Ed.D. Ryder Delaloye, Associate Director for the SEE Learning Program at Emory University in Atlanta.

This session aimed to empower higher education practitioners to apply research-based strategies to their classrooms and professional work. The integration of awareness, resilience, attention training, compassion for self and others, systems thinking, and other traits as guided by the Science of Compassion is helping organisations fulfill their true vision of education and student growth.

Participants tested practical and personal tools in addition to testing resources that have been developed and put into action by higher education practitioners around the world.

A majority of the participants thought that the meeting was inspiring, the course was useful for their work and that they learned something new. The participants appreciated the presentation but at the same time thought that it was a lot to process. Some suggestions were to have a break or leave more time for discussion. The participants gave the event a 4,7/5 overall rating, and they felt that they learned something new, giving a 4.4/5 rating. On the BUP website, you can read the full event report from the BUP Teachers' Day 2024.



The participants at the BUP Teachers' Day 2024 were given an introduction to SEE Learning (Social, Emotional and Ethical Learning).

Photo: Cecilia Lundberg



Ed.D. Ryder Delaloye, Emory University in Atlanta, gave a presentation at the BUP Teachers' Day.

Photo: Cecilia Lundberg

"What I take with me are my reflections on the fact that a teacher teaches with their whole self, and emotions play an incredibly important role in the learning process, so developing self-awareness is crucial for teachers."

Quote from Katarzyna Mikolajczyk, one of the participants at the BUP Teachers' Day.

BUP Teachers Course 2023-2024

This was the fifth edition of this event targeted at teachers at BUP participating universities. This course is organised by the BUP Associated Secretariat and the National Centre in Finland, located at the Centre for Lifelong Learning, Åbo Akademi University.

The aim of the course, and its study process, is to support university teachers to integrate Education for Sustainable Development (ESD) into their teaching and courses to strengthen the implementation of the United Nations Sustainable Development Goals. The teachers were PhD Shepherd Urenje from Uppsala University, PhD Cecilia Lundberg, and MSc Sinikka Suomlainen, both from Åbo Akademi University. This was the last time that Sinikka, who has been working with the BUP since the beginning more than 30 years ago, took part in organising the course. From all of us, a big BUP thanks to you Sinikka!

During the course, each participant develops a so-called 'Change project' to work with at their home university. The 'Change project' is based on an already existing course, study program, or a future teaching experience. The idea is to change the content to better integrate ESD. The planning and implementation of the 'Change project' is the main outcome of the course. The course corresponds to 5 ECTS credit points (133 hours) at the Centre for Lifelong Learning, Åbo Akademi University, Finland.

Different learning methods were introduced during the course with a focus on e-learning, peer learning, and workshops. As a learning outcome, each participant planned and developed a 'Change project' to improve the integration of ESD in their current or future work. The 'Change projects' were supported by peer reviews via the e-platform and during the workshops. During the workshops, keynotes with a focus on learning in higher education at the hosting university were also part of the program.

In 2024 year there were 25 teachers from Estonia, Finland, Germany, Latvia, Lithuania, Poland, Sweden and Ukraine who took part. They represented 20 different BUP participating universities and approximately 20 different areas of specialty, from urban planning to nursing and geometry. As a part of the RESCUU project (see page 10), the BUP awarded six travel grants to those Ukrainian teachers who got accepted to participate in the course.

The feedback survey generated a positive response from both workshops – the overall grade (on a scale of 1-5) was 4,6. The participants thought that both workshops inspired them in their work, that they were useful for their work, and resulted in new insights about ESD which they will try to apply in their own teaching. The participants thought that the course met their expectations, giving an overall rating of 4,7/5.



Participants at the workshop held at Riga Technical University in September 2023.

Photo: Cecilia Lundberg

"I will take away immediate ideas on innovative teaching methods and the value of diverse backgrounds in enriching the learning experience. The course reinforced my belief that we should focus on teaching students the skills they need to solve future sustainability challenges rather than just providing them with ready solutions."

Quote from Anastasia Tsvetkova, one of the participants in the BUP Teachers Course.



Participants at the workshop held at the Warsaw School of Economics in March 2024. Pictured from the left are Olena Vrublevska, Ivan Franko National University of L'viv, and Polina Stegantseva, Zaporizhzhia National University.

Photo: Cecilia Lundberg



PhD Shepherd Urenje from Uppsala University gave a presentation at the workshop held at Riga Technical University in September 2023.

Photo: Cecilia Lundberg



Participants at the workshop held at the Warsaw School of Economics in March 2024.

Photo: Cecilia Lundberg

Researchers

One of the main aims of The Baltic University Programme is to promote a strong regional research community in the field of sustainability. This is done by building research networks according to the 10 BUP themes, coordinating publications and grant calls through the BUP Research and Publication Office (BUPRaP), research events and calls as well as arranging the BUP Symposium related to the 10 BUP themes.

Page 26

BUP PhD Award

Page 27

BUP Mobility Grant

Page 28

BUPRaP Roadshow

Page 29

Research within the BUP

BUP PhD Award

This award is given to the authors of what is judged to be the most qualified PhD work defended at a participating university in the past year. The winners receive a diploma and support of up to 1000 € for attending a scientific conference or publishing in a peer-reviewed scientific journal. The award aims to support high-quality research promoting sustainable development in a Baltic Sea Region context.

Winner in the category of Natural Sciences and Engineering



PhD Weifeng Lin
Uppsala University

Title: Development of advanced chemical biology tools for microbiome metabolism. Chemoselective probes for enhanced metabolomics analysis

Supervisor: Daniel Globisch

Motivation
The author developed chemical metabolomics tools for qualitative and quantitative analysis of metabolites in human and bacterial samples utilizing chemoselective probes immobilized onto magnetic beads. The work required a multidisciplinary approach involving several disciplines such as integrated organic chemistry, chemical biology, analytical chemistry, biotechnology, biomedicine, and computational analysis. The PhD thesis is highly innovative, because the method developed by Dr Lin improves the mass spectrometric sensitivity by up to a factor of one million with exceptional sensitivity and reproducibility. Application of the methodology elaborated in the frame of the work resulted in the discovery of four valuable nutritional biomarkers. The chemical metabolomics tool compiled by Dr Lin provides valuable insights into microbial interactions with the human body and the development of diseases. The PhD thesis is based on five Q1 peer-reviewed papers and five additional papers, which underlines the high scientific quality of this work. Additionally, the results of the thesis support the sustainable development in the BSR in the context of environmental monitoring and improvement of public health.

Winner in the category of Social Sciences and Humanities



PhD Tony Blomqvist Mickelsson
Södertörn University

Title: A Nordic sport social work in the context of refugee reception

Supervisors: Jani Turunen, Hanna Bertilsdotter-Rosqvist and Noora Ronkainen

Photo: Albert Hjalmers

Motivation
The UN Sustainable Development Goals encompass economic, social, and environmental dimensions. The research on social sustainability and resilience within communities in the Baltic Sea Region is relatively recent. In his thesis, Tony Blomqvist Mickelsson focuses on the role of Swedish voluntary sports clubs in enabling marginalised populations' participation in sports, and in acting to integrate sports into mainstream social work tradition. The author focuses specifically on the reception of Ukrainian refugees, and he reaches his conclusions on the base of interviews and participant observation used in an innovative way with the help of highly relevant theories, concepts, and methods. Blomqvist's findings suggest that while sports clubs face challenges in their work related to resource availability and consistency, a fact observed across migrant populations, Ukrainian refugees present a unique picture, since their prior experience of organised and competitive sports facilitates an easier integration, at the same time as they often are perceived as being 'closer' to the dominant culture in the receiving country. As a result, Swedish sports clubs generally display a more favorable attitude towards the inclusion of Ukrainian refugees, which highlights a potential double standard in the refugee reception. Further, Blomqvist has introduced the concept of sports social work to regional and national sports federations, and he has contributed to the popularisation of his own research by participating in various projects. With his research, Tony Blomqvist Mickelsson contributes in an important way to the growing research topic on the role of sports in the social integration of refugees, and the results can be used in the service of creating a more sustainable development in the Baltic Sea Region.

BUP Mobility Grant

The aim of the grant is to develop and strengthen cooperation among young researchers in the Baltic Sea Region, at BUP participating universities, by covering travel and accommodation for a research project. The awarded maximum is a total value of 3000 Euros.



PhD Mariia Kaidash
State Scientific Institution "Institute for Single Crystals" of National Academy of Sciences of Ukraine

The grant is intended to support young scholars in their research on sustainable development. For an applicant to be eligible to receive the grant they need to have finished their PhD in the past 5 years. The applications can be made for the funding of new research projects (in whole or in part), or as a financial contribution to ongoing ones - as long as the applicant stays at another university in the Baltic Sea Region during the Mobility Grant period.

Mariia Kaidash, previously representing V. N. Karazin Kharkiv National University, and the project 'Detection of anthropogenic pollutants in surface waters by new materials' won the BUP Mobility Grant 2024.

Mariia shares the following outcomes of the project:

- Establishment of a research partnership between Swedish and Ukrainian teams.
- Development of a sustainable system for the detection and removal of mercury pollution from open water sources.
- Synthesis of six mercury-specific adsorbents at Uppsala University.
- Synthesis of three mercury-sensitive dyes by the Ukrainian research team.
- Ongoing elemental analysis of newly developed adsorbents at the University of Rostock, Germany.
- Planned fluorometric evaluation of heavy metal adsorption using the synthesized fluorescent dyes following elemental analysis.
- Future publication of research findings upon completion of all experimental studies.

On the BUP website, you can read more about the Mobility Grant as well as Mariias Mobility Grant report in full.

BUPRaP Roadshow

The BUP Research and Publications Office (BUPRaP) has, as a part of its efforts to support colleagues at BUP participating universities in strengthening their research and publication profiles, offered the 'BUPRaP Roadshow', two research-focused seminars.

The BUP Research and Publications Office (BUPRaP) is a research and publication infrastructure led by the BUP Associated Secretariat at Hamburg University of Applied Sciences in Germany (HAW Hamburg). It aims to support The Baltic University Programme in developing its research infrastructure and foster the capacity to publish research in peer-reviewed journals. The seminars within the BUPRaP Roadshow last about 2,5 hours each and can be offered in combination, to maximise the time investment. In 2024 the BUPRaP Roadshow was held in Czechia, Estonia, Finland, Latvia, and Poland. The seminars have been led by Professor Walter Leal, Head of the BUP Associate Secretariat at HAW Hamburg. These are the two Roadshow seminars:

'Optimising Efforts in Scientific Publishing on Sustainable Development'

This seminar explores the key elements of scientific publishing, including manuscript preparation, peer review, ethical considerations, publication metrics, and future trends. It also outlines the details of the scientific publishing process, including the types of scientific publications, the roles of authors, reviewers, and editors, and the importance of publishing for researchers. Tips and strategies for selecting the right journal to submit your research paper (journal's scope, impact factor, audience, and editorial policies) are also provided. A questions and answers section is included, to allow researchers to present their paper ideas, and offer advice on potential journals which they may consider for publishing their work.

'Fostering Scientific Cooperation via European and Non-European Funded Projects on Sustainable Development'

This seminar explores the advantages of scientific cooperation on matters related to sustainable development, and describes the role of major networks such as The Baltic University Programme, the European School of Sustainability Science and Research and others, as a source of information on project funding. In addition, the seminar will introduce a variety of European and non-European funding programmes, which may be accessed by members of The Baltic University Programme, as possible funding sources for their projects. A questions and answers section is included, to allow researchers to present their project ideas, and offer advice on potential funding sources.



Walter Leal giving a presentation at Åbo Akademi University in Finland.

Photo: Mia Henriksson



Participants at the BUPRaP Roadshow held at Tallinn University in Estonia.

Photo: Tiina Elvisto

"The best part of the event was to get relevant information and recommendations on research funding and publications from a highly qualified academic person."

Quote from Katrin Männik, one of the participants at the BUPRaP Roadshow in Estonia.

Research within the BUP

One of the main aims of The Baltic University Programme is to build a strong regional research community by promoting inter-, multi-, and transdisciplinary research for a sustainable Baltic Sea Region.

The research being conducted at BUP participating universities is an important source of knowledge being used to increase the quality of all our events. We strive towards creating opportunities for researchers at BUP participating universities to meet and cooperate with each other. This is done in part by giving financial support to research events, such as BUP Presidency events, and sharing calls related to research within the Programme.

One way of promoting research collaboration is via the research networks within the ten BUP themes that we present on the BUP website. Each BUP theme gives researchers the possibility to learn more about fellow colleagues and the focus of their research.

Researchers also get the chance to take part in and contribute to the BUP Symposium, Supervisor Collegium, and the BUP Course Platform.

To establish new ways to communicate research within the BUP a survey was sent out to researchers within the Programme in the autumn 2024. After an analysis of the answers, the BUP Coordinating Secretariat plans to launch a research profile to be published once a month with a researcher or a project to be featured on LinkedIn and in the BUP Weekly.

BUP Research and Publications Office (BUPRaP)

The BUPRaP is moving forward by encouraging Baltic Sea Region (BSR) researchers to collaborate on joint project proposals and joint scientific publications in high-impact journals. One example of this is the collaboration in the Interreg project BALTIPLAST, and the publication of a paper in 2024 about measures to prevent plastic pollution in the BSR. The paper is entitled *An assessment of the scope and effectiveness of soft measures to handle plastic pollution in the Baltic Sea Region* which was published in the Marine Pollution Bulletin (Elsevier).

Considering the increasing involvement of circular approaches when tackling environmental issues, in 2025 the BUPRaP will support further initiatives from the BSR researchers to contribute to this topic. In collaboration with the new National Center for Germany (Hamburg University of Applied Sciences) the Symposium specially designed for young researchers 'Fostering Circular Solutions for Plastic Pollution in the Baltic Sea Region' will be held in Hamburg on 22-24 September 2025.

BUP Research and Publication Office

BUPRaP is hosted by the BUP Associated Secretariat at the Hamburg University of Applied Sciences in Germany and it is led by Professor Walter Leal.

Students

The Baltic University Programme organises several events and conferences each year intended for students studying at bachelor-, master- and PhD level. Organising is often a joint project between two or several BUP participating universities. All our activities are focusing on one or several of our 10 BUP themes. Events are open for students from all BUP participating universities.

Page 32

BUP Student Conference

Page 34

BUP Science and Sail

Page 36

BUP Master Thesis Training

BUP Student Conference

The 2024 BUP Student Conference was held between 15-18 April at Poznan University of Technology. The event welcomed 89 students from all 10 countries within the BUP, who represented 47 universities. This conference was held as part of the RESCUU project and the title was 'Changed circumstances and new threats for sustainability in the Baltic Sea Region'.

The central aim of BUP student conferences, as well as the RESCUU project, is to bring together students from around the Baltic Sea Region with a focus on an issue of key importance within sustainability science and stimulate inter-cultural exchange in an academic and interdisciplinary setting. Promoting academic cooperation, developing networking, and spreading sustainability knowledge are important objectives for the BUP, and this conference was developed with these aims in mind.

The conference was developed together with all partners involved in the RESCUU project and included contributions from Ukraine, Poland, and Sweden. As with many of our events, the BUP looks to facilitate a platform for a common understanding of regional challenges and possibilities and open avenues for future cooperation on these issues. The war in Ukraine is of relevance to all in the region, and its effects are widespread. Therefore, this conference looked to approach the current conflict in the region from a sustainability standpoint, increasing knowledge amongst students and allowing them to network with fellow peers.

An important part of the conference is the Students' Parliament. It is an opportunity for student decision-making to take center stage and to increase their voice within the BUP. A key point is the election of a new Student Representative to the BUP Board. Congratulations to Paul Grohmann who was elected to the position. Thanks must also be passed to Tereza Homolova who after the conference completed her time as a BUP Student Representative.

There were many positives demonstrated in the feedback. The varied program was particularly appreciated. Of note was the Baltic Debate. The students appreciated the chance to develop debating skills, learn about a new topic and engage in a friendly but competitive atmosphere. Many of the social activities at the conference were also appreciated. These included a Cultural Party as well as activities run by students. Giving students the opportunity to develop connections in both an academic and personal setting is important for the BUP.

In addition to the activities at the conference, and the conference itself, the evaluation also asked the students about the future and the experiences that they have gained. The students gave a rating of 8.7/10 in response to the question of to what extent the conference has been worthwhile to attend in terms of studies, future aspirations and career. Students gave the event an overall rating of 9.3/10. On the BUP website, you can read the full event report from the BUP Student Conference 2024.



The attending students elected Paul Grohmann, representing Lund University, as their new Student Representative for a two-year term on the BUP International Board.

Photo: Pontus Ambros

"I liked debates the most, because everybody was involved. I gained experience in public speaking and brainstorming."

"Loved to meet like minded people, who made me see things in different perspectives."

Students quotes from the evaluation.



At many of the lectures, the students had the opportunity to discuss and work hands-on with the subjects in focus.

Photo: Pontus Ambros



At the 'Cultural party', the participants were treated to a performance of the dance Polonez which is one of the Polish national dances.

Photo: Pontus Ambros



Magdalena Lachowicz, Adam Mickiewicz University, gave a lecture on the opening day. The title was 'Russia as a threat and potential for peace building in the Baltic States Region'.

Photo: Pontus Ambros



The students were divided into groups at the 'Baltic Debate' during which they were to debate for or against nuclear power. After a fruitful debate, the side who spoke against nuclear power were the winners of the debate.

Photo: Khrystyna Martyniak



This edition of the BUP Student Conference welcomed a total of 89 students from all 10 countries within the BUP, who represented 47 universities.

Photo: Pontus Ambros

BUP Science and Sail

The BUP Science and Sail summer school was held in Klaipeda, Lithuania, hosted by Klaipeda University in August 2024. The summer school focused on the Baltic Sea Environment, with students studying on both sea and land with leading experts from across the region.

The BUP summer schools offer students the chance to conduct hands-on fieldwork related to issues of sustainability and the ability to take part in a diverse program, all whilst discovering a new location in the Baltic Sea Region and meeting a new group of peers. A total of 36 students and 3 PhD students from 33 of the BUP participating universities and all 10 countries within the BUP joined the event.

The summer school program consisted of four days of fieldwork, based in and around Klaipeda, as well as three days at the Klaipeda University campus. Activities included;

- Baltic Sea Hydrology; onboard the tall-ship s/v *Brabander,* investigating river plumes, water transparency, and depth profiles of water salinity and oxygen.
- Field trip to the Curonian Spit National Park- guided tours involving studies of the unique ecosystem of the spit and its cultural heritage.
- Visit to the great Cormorant colony at Lake Plaze, taking part in sample collection and studying the ecological impacts of the colony.
- Field trip to the Nemunas' Delta, visiting old and new settlements in the river delta and learning of their significance to the region.

The students also attended lectures, went on specialised site visits to Klaipeda University's Botanical Garden, took part in a guided tour, gave presentations and worked throughout on various pedagogical tasks within the program.

BUP summer schools and Science and Sail in particular, aim at giving students from participating universities the chance to meet, discuss, network, sample and research scientific issues with a focus on sustainability in an international and interdisciplinary manner. This summer school helps to enrich the students' perspectives about sustainability and the Baltic Sea Region with new experiences and viewpoints. The summer school thus serves as a realisation of regional issues- both challenges and solutions.

All participating students were asked to complete an evaluation on the final day of the summer school. This was completed by all 36 of the students. Prior to the event, students held an average expectation of 7.5/10 and the event ended up getting an 8.7/10 overall rating. Some of the highest ratings were given to the day on the tall ship Brabander and the visit to the Cormorant bird colony. The participating students noted that the event was worthwhile attending, giving an 8.1/10 rating, resulting in an increased interest in the Baltic Sea Region and its environment. On the BUP website, you can read the full event report from the BUP Science and Sail 2024.



The students got the opportunity to climb and work in the masts.

Photo: Pontus Ambros

"I will take from the course a better knowledge about the Baltic Sea and all the lessons I learned about sustainability. Having talked with other students from different countries, fields, and backgrounds, I gained new perspectives and insights that I would not have encountered otherwise."

Quote from Elisa Hyvärinen, one of the students who took part in the summer school.



Participants and organisers gathered after the closing ceremony of the Science and Sail at Klaipeda University.

Photo: Pontus Ambros



The participants were divided into groups for the workshop 'Land-use and sustainability in the Baltic Sea Region'. The students represented all 10 countries within the BUP.

Photo: Pontus Ambros



The students spend time on the tall ship Brabander. There they focused on water sampling, depth profiles and salinity investigations.

Photo: Pontus Ambros



One excursion was to the Great Cormorant (Phalacrocorax carbo) colony, studying the diminishing population and how they help us remove invasive species. The guide was Dr. Julius Morkunas, Klaipeda University.

Photo: Pontus Ambros

BUP Master Thesis Training

This training aims to offer master students from the Baltic Sea Region the opportunity to come together, interact and network with fellow students and experts in an interdisciplinary and regional setting with the thesis in focus. The BUP focuses on academic cooperation and sustainability science, and this is one event by which the BUP looks to facilitate these aims, particularly amongst students.

The Master Thesis Training (MTT) took place at Uppsala University between 25-28 March 2024. The MTT aims to give master students from the BUP participating universities the possibility to meet and discuss scientific problems with a focus on sustainability in an interdisciplinary, international, multicultural, and regional context. In this way, students will also have the opportunity to become acquainted with other universities and their scientific traditions.

The master thesis is at the center of the event, which aims, through all of its activities, to enhance and positively contribute to each student's thesis and each student's academic thesis capabilities. To accomplish this objective, the event features a number of feedback sessions, both from fellow peers in a student opposition and from regional experts in a one-to-one session, as well as the chance to present their thesis and lead a discussion. A new objective for this edition of the event was a more enhanced focus on sustainability science and critical academic capabilities in a general sense. The MTT looked to contribute to these points with dedicated workshops on sustainability thinking and critical thinking, further contributing to a wider understanding.

There were many positives shared in the evaluation of the event. Of particular note was the individual counselling session with both students and staff reflecting positively, presentations from other students, the academic atmosphere and student oppositions. Students were highly appreciative of the individual feedback sessions with an expert, which has led to productive results including; better linking the overall thread in the thesis, discussions about methodologies, tips about writing, motivation and inspiration for the future. The students gave a rating of 9/10 in response to the question of to what extent the MTT has been worthwhile in attending in terms of studies, future aspirations and career. The students gave the event a 9,2/10 overall rating and the supervisors gave the event a 9,6/10 overall rating.

Some changes to the program were also discussed. There is the potential for extending the event by one day to allow for greater feedback opportunities and more time to process this. Of note too is the option to provide a short session on how to give feedback effectively in an opposition. Being a 'critical friend' is an important and valuable skill, and so this would be very effective for the future. On the BUP website, you can read the full event report from the BUP Master Thesis Training 2024.



Each student gave a presentation of their master thesis. Here is Christina Skjolding Hjelm from Lund University.

Photo: Pontus Ambros

"Sustainability has always been a topic of great interest to me, so it was fantastic to expand my knowledge during this event. I was amazed by how helpful everyone was in guiding me through my thesis project, and our discussions on sustainability were incredibly engaging."

Quote from Andersson Cueva, one of the students who took part in the Master Thesis Training.



Students and supervisors that took part in the Master Thesis Training. The picture is taken at Geocentrum at Uppsala University.

Photo: Pontus Ambros



Each student had one on one time with their supervisors and received feedback on their thesis.

Photo: Pontus Ambros



As the participants presented their thesis they would get initial feedback and questions from the other master students.

Photo: Pontus Ambros



Pictured is Joosep Aia from the University of Tartu presenting his thesis.

Photo: Pontus Ambros

BUP organisation

The Baltic University Programme is coordinated by the BUP Coordinating Secretariat at Uppsala University, Sweden. Moreover, three BUP Associated Secretariats in Finland, Germany and Poland have specialised tasks. The BUP National Centres deal with network coordination and host national meetings in each BUP country. The long term development and the strategy of the BUP are attended to by the BUP International Board.

Page 40

Participating universities

Page 41

BUP IROs Network

Page 42

Organisational structure

Page 43

The Secretariats

Page 46

The National Centres

Page 47

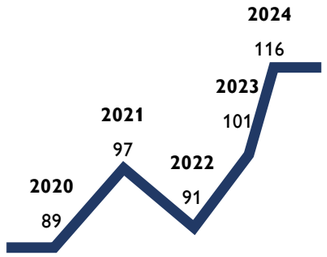
BUP communication

Participating universities

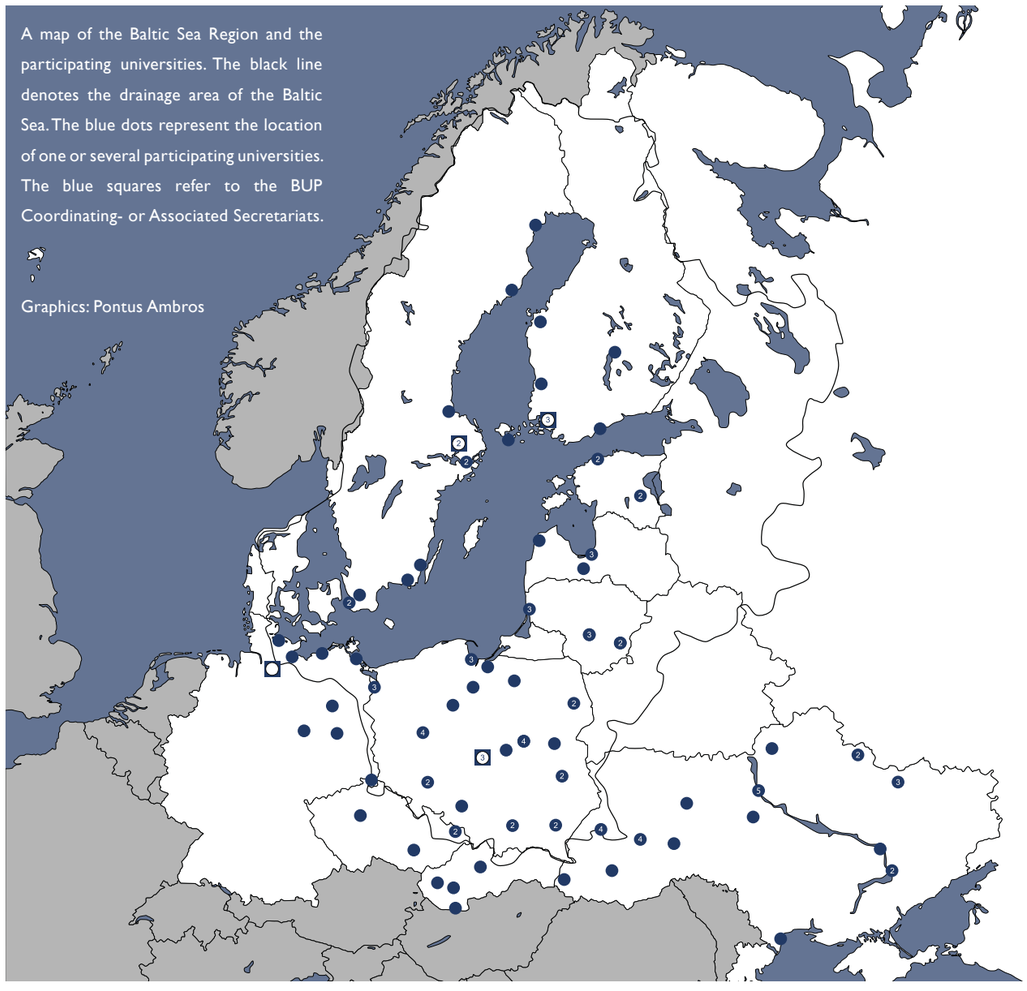
All participating universities have signed an inter-university agreement to be a part of the BUP. At the end of 2024, we had 116 members in the Programme.

Participating universities are an integral part of the BUP; they help shape the outline of the Programme as well as its activities and outcome. Joining the BUP opens up for possibilities to become involved in the cooperation and work being conducted within the Programme to promote internationalisation with a focus on sustainability and democracy.

In the past year, there has been an increase of engaged colleagues and students and we have been joined by 18 new universities. This resulted in the highest number of universities in Poland - 34 - followed by Ukraine where there were 28 universities at the end of 2024.



The continued increase in the number of universities is a result of the Coordinating Secretariat, National Centres, Associated Secretariats and colleagues' common effort in sharing information about the BUP with possible new partners.



A map of the Baltic Sea Region and the participating universities. The black line denotes the drainage area of the Baltic Sea. The blue dots represent the location of one or several participating universities. The blue squares refer to the BUP Coordinating- or Associated Secretariats.

Graphics: Pontus Ambros

BUP IROs Network

This network is for colleagues working with internationalisation issues at BUP participating universities. The network aims to foster stronger collaboration, partnerships, and closer connections, within The Baltic University Programme, particularly in the areas of internationalisation and sustainability.

The initiative to create the network came from colleagues at the Center for International Cooperation at the University of Ostrava. The idea was supported by the participants at the BUP meeting of International Relations Officers (IROs) on 7-8 October 2024. Around 50 colleagues from the IROs at BUP participating universities gathered at the University of Ostrava to discuss issues related to internationalisation and cooperation. The meeting led to the establishment of the BUP IROs Network.

Within the network, there are regular online meetings. These sessions provide participants with the opportunity to raise relevant topics, discuss areas of concern, and explore ways to further collaborate with each other and within the BUP. There is also a LinkedIn group, 'The Baltic University Programme's group for IROs', which will serve as a platform for communication and networking.



Lyudmyla Babak and Lara Kerschl from the BUP Coordinating Secretariat are working together with colleagues within the IROs Network to enable network meetings and to enable the growth of the network.

Photo: Klára Šmiráková



Pictured is Ivana Adamikova, second from the left. Ivana is the BUP National Centre Director in Czechia and together with her colleagues at the National Centre, she took the initiative to host the meeting as a part of the BUP Presidency in Czechia.

Photo: Klára Šmiráková

Organisational structure

The Programme has a structure where the participating universities are included and can impact all that the BUP has to offer. Thoughts and ideas can be passed through the organisation via the BUP National Centres and Associated Secretariats to the BUP Coordinating Secretariat and the BUP International Board.



The BUP organisational structure.

The BUP International Board 2024

Input regarding strategic decisions and ideas about the overall direction of the BUP comes mainly from the International Board and is implemented by the Secretariats and participating universities. From July 2024 the BUP has a new International Board.

Chair of the board
Olle Jansson,
Uppsala University, Sweden

Tapio Salmi, Prof.
Åbo Akademi University, Finland

Walter Leal, Prof.
Hamburg University of Applied Sciences, Germany

Cecilia Johansson, Dr.
Uppsala University, Sweden

Jonathan Schalk
Uppsala University, Sweden

Elin Slätmo, Dr.
Representative from Swedish society, Nordregio

Joakim Ekman, Prof.
Södertörn University, Sweden

Visvaldas Varzinskas, Dr.
Kaunas University of Technology, Lithuania

Gunilla Rosenqvist, Dr.
Uppsala University, Sweden

Aleksandra Zieminska-Stolarska, Dr.
Lodz University of Technology, Poland

Student representatives

Niumi Dissanayake
Poznan University of Technology, Poland

Paul Grohmann
Lund University, Sweden

The Secretariats

The extensive network is supported, for administration, organisation, and strategic planning, by a Coordinating Secretariat at Uppsala University, Sweden, and three Associated Secretariats situated at Lodz University of Technology (Poland), Åbo Akademi University (Finland), and Hamburg University of Applied Sciences (Germany).

The Associated Secretariats

The scope of the BUP activities, projects and events is wide and ranges from those targeted at students to those aimed at university teachers and researchers. Therefore, the BUP has three Associated Secretariats, each in charge of a specific BUP domain. Their budgets come from local funding.

Hamburg University of Applied Sciences

The German Associated Secretariat deals with research development in the network and they host the BUP Research and Publications Office (BUPRaP), which assists participating universities in fostering their research activities and enhancing their publications output and profile. Works with creating opportunities for young researchers as well as seasoned scholars.



Head of Secretariat
Walter Leal
Prof.

Lodz University of Technology

The Polish Associated Secretariat deals with the organisation of network wide courses and conferences. This can be PhD student trainings, student conferences, symposiums and projects. From 2025, Aleksandra Ziemiska-Stolarska will be head of the Associated Secretariat.



Head of Secretariat
Ireneusz Zbicinski
Prof.

Åbo Akademi University

The Finnish Associated Secretariat's core mission is the professional development of university teachers and it works mainly within the theme of Education for Sustainable Development (ESD). Equipped with this expertise, it provides the Programme with an efficient and innovative platform for the BUP teachers' professional growth.



Head of Secretariat
Cecilia Lundberg
Dr.

The Coordinating Secretariat

The central body for administrative and organisational support as well as for strategic work and long term planning within the BUP is the Coordinating Secretariat which is located at Uppsala University.

Head of the Coordinating Secretariat. The main responsibilities are the strategic aspects of the Programme; lead, plan and implement the strategy. The Director also supports the Programme at an academic and research level and seeks new ways of strengthening the scientific impact of Programme participants.



Director
Madeleine Granvik
Assoc. Prof.

Responsible for projects, such as RESCUU and CAPABLE, and represents a key figure in the practical running of the organisation, which includes inviting and welcoming new universities, economic matters, and ensuring networking and strong levels of overall contact with the Programme's participating universities. Works with the BUP IROs Network.



Project coordinator
Lyudmyla Babak
MA

Focuses primarily on designing and executing projects and organising activities aimed at students from participating universities. Pontus is in charge of the BUP Student Conference and also focuses on the BUP Course Platform and works with the Student Representatives.



Project administrator
Pontus Ambros
MSc

Worked with coordinating new courses for the BUP Course Platform and with the BUP Master Thesis Training as well as the BUP Student Conference. Was responsible for the Supervisor Collegium as well as the BUP Course Platform. Worked up until June 2024.



Project administrator
Evan Goss
MSS

Works with coordinating courses for the BUP Course Platform and with the BUP IROs Network as well as with student activities and with the Student Representatives. Organises the BUP Master Thesis Training, BUP Student Conference and BUP Science and Sail. Started working in September 2024.



Project administrator
Lara Kerschl
MSc

Works with the BUP Symposium, PhD Students Training and the Supervisor Collegium as well as with student activities and with the Student Representatives. Organises the BUP Master Thesis Training and the BUP Student Conference. Started working in October 2024.



Project administrator
Kiana Islamian
MSc

The Coordinating Secretariat

Maintains the presence of the BUP on social media and, among other things, edits the newsletter BUP Weekly and the Annual Report. Takes care of informational and promotional material as well as the BUP website and other communication issues. Administers the BUP educational material bank.



Communications officer
Adam Söderberg
BA

Worked mainly with organisational issues and supported the Coordinating Secretariat. Had a specific focus on broadening the knowledge of how the BUP as an organisation could work with data and information/knowledge management.



Intern
Elia Francesco Blangero
MA

The National Centres

In all 10 countries within the BUP, there is a National Centre. These deal with network coordination and host national meetings. Each National Centre is under the leadership of a Centre Director.

The National Centres are located at participating universities and consist of colleagues with experience in cooperation, event planning and communication. In 2024 there was a process to appoint five National Centres and in Lithuania, Slovakia and Ukraine we welcomed a new participating university as a host of the BUP National Centre.

The BUP National Centre Directors 2024



Czech Republic
Ivana Adamiková
University of Ostrava



Estonia
Tiina Elvisto
Tallinn University



Finland
Cecilia Lundberg
Åbo Akademi University



Germany
Jakob Hildebrandt
Zittau/Görlitz University of Applied Sciences
(Former)



Germany
Walter Leal
Hamburg University of Applied Sciences
(Current)



Latvia
Laura Štale
Riga Technical University



Lithuania
Visvaldas Varzinskas
Kaunas University of Technology
(Former)



Lithuania
Eduardas Spiriajevas
Klaipda University
(Current)



Poland
Ireneusz Zbicinski
Łodz University of Technology



Slovakia
Barbora Cakovská
Slovak University of Agriculture in Nitra
(Former)



Slovakia
Nikoleta Vanková
University of Ss. Cyril and Methodius in Trnava
(Current)



Sweden
Per Bolin
Södertörn University



Ukranie
Iryna Kriba
Ivan Franko National University of Lviv
(Former)



Ukranie
Zoriana Dvulit
Lviv Polytechnic National University
(Current)

BUP communication

With close to 120 participating universities, the BUP and its engaged colleagues can reach and cooperate with a large number of people with diverse backgrounds to facilitate their networking and communication. The continued growth and reach of the Programme show that together we can accomplish great things in relation to sustainable development and democracy in the Baltic Sea Region.

In 2024 we have seen a continued strong interest in what the BUP has to offer and with events within the BUP Presidency, for the Supervisor Collegium and the CAPABLE-project, there has been a broad offer of events and calls. There have been record applications to some of our events and increasing interest from colleagues to share their university calls and announcements within the Programme.

We distribute the BUP Weekly, our Annual Report and event announcements as well as calls via our mailing lists. We have different lists for contact persons at our participating universities and for a broader group of subscribers – anyone who is interested in the BUP can subscribe and receive updates from us. The contact persons e-mail list had 613 subscribers (a decrease of about 1,5% during the past year), and the generic list had 4004 subscribers (an increase of about 10% during the past year) at the end of 2024. We always add e-mail addresses to our lists with the subscribers' consent. The continued increase in subscribers can be attributed to the fact that many applicants to our events choose to subscribe to our email list.

Communication material published in 2024 consisted of 22 issues of the BUP Weekly and the 2022 Annual Report.

Facebook

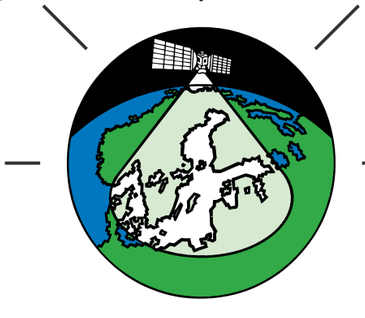
The BUP Facebook page was established in 2011 and had 2,181 followers at the end of 2024. This meant an increase of about 6% during the past year.

Instagram

The BUP Instagram was established in February 2020 and it had 456 followers at the end of 2024. This is an increase of 20% during the past year. In May 2022, the BUP Student Instagram channel was established and it had 320 followers at the end of 2024, an increase of about 37%.

Website

The total number of website visits during 2024 was 22,188 (compared to 42,331 in 2023). In the past year, there have been multiple events hosted by participating universities and fewer big student events which are usually the most popular. This can explain the drop in website visits.



LinkedIn

The channel was established in 2016 and had 577 followers at the end of 2024. This is an increase of about 37% during the past year.

YouTube

The channel was established in 2008, and had 464 subscribers at the end of 2024. This is an increase of about 7% during the past year.



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